

John W. Z. Zhang

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Education

Stanford University

Autumn 2026

Visiting Student Researcher

- Sponsor: Prof. Gary Cox.

London School of Economics and Political Science

Sep 2023 – Autumn 2026

PhD in Economic History

- Fields: Economic History, Political Economy.
- Supervisors: Prof. Patrick Wallis and Prof. Mohamed Saleh.
- Teaching Assistance: Theories and Evidence in Economic History; The Family Economy in History.

London School of Economics and Political Science

Sep 2022 – Nov 2023

MSc in Economic History

- Graduated with Merit (70.88%).
- Dissertation ranked 2nd in the cohort (out of 100+).

University of Bath

Sep 2019 – Jul 2022

BSc (Hons) Economics

- Graduated with First-class honours.
- Dissertation ranked 1st in the cohort (out of 300+).

Job Market Paper

Welfare Retrenchment and Social Unrest [🔗](#)

2026

Abstract: Does welfare retrenchment cause social unrest? I study this question using parish-level expenditure on poor relief and data on social unrest in post-Napoleonic England, drawing on the 1818-9 welfare reforms to motivate instrumental variables, regression discontinuity, and event study research designs. The reduced-form analysis finds a causal effect of welfare retrenchment on social unrest between 1816 and 1834, attributable to an exacerbation of relative deprivation that stems from comparisons with higher-expenditure parishes. Simulations from a counterfactual analysis assuming greater accountability for these grievances highlight the importance of equitable social welfare provision in minimising the political costs of austerity.

Working Papers

Deskilling and Unrest [🔗](#)

Endogenous Revolutionary Threat [🔗](#)

Next Release

Austerity Origins of the Great Reform Act

2026

Dataset

Egyptian Parliamentary Speeches, 1924-1952 (with Mohamed Saleh) [🔗](#)

2025

Methods: Computer Vision; Generative AI.

Presentations

- 2026:** Economic History Association Annual Meeting, St. Louis; Western Economic Association International Annual Conference, Denver; Workshop in Political Economy and Economic History, York; Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy, London; Frontier Research in Economic and Social History Workshop, Berlin; Economic History Society Annual Conference, London; Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2025:** PPE for Public Policy Graduate Conference, London; Graduate Seminar in Economic and Social History, University of Oxford; Economic and Social History Workshop, University of Cambridge; Graduate Economic History Seminar, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2024:** Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.

Other Credentials

Languages: English and Mandarin.

Technical Skills: Julia, MATLAB, Python, QGIS, R and Stata.